
Microsoft 365 Government Cloud Field Runbook

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A symptom-driven field reference for Microsoft 365 GCC, GCC High and DoD tenants. Organized by what the ticket says rather than by what the cause turns out to be.

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Sections 4 to 13 are the symptom index. Each entry reads symptom, likely causes ranked by frequency, the check, the fix, and how to stop it recurring.

1. The four clouds, and which one you are actually in

Most wasted hours in government tenant work trace back to treating all “gov” tenants as one thing.

The line that matters most: **GCC runs on commercial infrastructure**. Same endpoints, same Graph, same modules, no environment switches. What GCC buys is contractual — data residency, personnel screening, an authorization boundary. If a client says they are in GCC and your commercial scripts work unchanged, nothing is broken.

GCC High and DoD are separate sovereign instances. Different authority, different Graph, different portals, different Exchange and Teams environment parameters, a smaller app gallery, and a feature set trailing commercial by weeks to years.

	Commercial	GCC	GCC High	DoD
Identity plane	Commercial Entra	Commercial Entra	Sovereign	Sovereign
Login authority	<code>login.microsoftonline.com</code>	<code>login.microsoftonline.com</code>	<code>login.microsoftonline.us</code>	<code>login.microsoftonline.com</code>
Graph endpoint	<code>graph.microsoft.com</code>	<code>graph.microsoft.com</code>	<code>graph.microsoft.us</code>	<code>dod-graph.microsoft.com</code>
Authorization	none	FedRAMP High, DoD IL2	FedRAMP High, DoD IL4	DoD IL5
Typical driver	none	CJIS, FTI, state and local	CUI, ITAR, DFARS 7012, CMMC L2	DoD mission systems
Support staff	global	US persons screened	US persons screened	US persons

Why a client lands in GCC High

- **DFARS 252.204-7012** in the contract, requiring NIST SP 800-171 for covered defense information.
- **ITAR**, where technical data must stay in the US and be reachable only by US persons. Access by a foreign person is an export whether or not a file was downloaded.
- **CMMC Level 2** ahead of award, which is 800-171 plus a third-party assessment.

None of those *legally require* GCC High. A correctly configured commercial tenant can meet 800-171. GCC High gets chosen because Microsoft's screening, support model and FedRAMP High boundary remove a large share of the assessment burden. Know this distinction — “ITAR requires GCC High” is a common wrong answer.

What the difference costs you day to day

- Every PowerShell connection needs an environment parameter, and a missing one fails confusingly rather than cleanly.
- Third-party SaaS integrations work only if the vendor runs a GovCloud tenant and publishes into the sovereign app gallery.
- Microsoft 365 Lighthouse does not exist in GCC High, so an MSP has no native multi-tenant pane of glass.

- Commercial roadmap announcements do not apply. Check the Microsoft 365 Government service description before anything reaches a statement of work.

2. Tenant intake

Run this before touching anything in a tenant you inherited. Most “mystery” tickets in the first month are answered here.

Ten questions for the client

1. Which cloud — GCC, GCC High, or DoD? Ask for the initial `.onmicrosoft` domain rather than trusting the answer.
2. What compliance obligation drives it — DFARS 7012, ITAR, CMMC Level 2, CJIS? What is the assessment date?
3. Is CUI actually in the tenant today, and in which workloads?
4. Hybrid or cloud-only? If hybrid: password hash sync, pass-through, or federation?
5. Who holds Global Administrator, and is PIM in use?
6. Which partner organizations do they collaborate with, and are any in the commercial cloud?
7. What line-of-business applications authenticate against the tenant, and how?
8. What is the device estate — Intune-managed, co-managed, or unmanaged?
9. Who was the previous administrator or MSP, and is their access removed?
10. Where is the existing documentation, and when was it last true?

First ninety minutes of technical discovery

```
Connect-MgGraph -Environment USGov -Scopes `
    'Directory.Read.All','Policy.Read.All','RoleManagement.Read.Directory'

# What cloud does the session actually believe it is in?
Get-MgContext | Select-Object Environment, TenantId, Scopes

# Licensing tells you which controls are even available
Invoke-MgGraphRequest -Uri 'v1.0/subscribedSkus' -OutputType PSObject |
    Select-Object -ExpandProperty value |
    Select-Object skuPartNumber, @{n='Consumed';e={$_.consumedUnits}}

# Conditional Access inventory, including report-only policies nobody promoted
Invoke-MgGraphRequest -Uri 'v1.0/identity/conditionalAccess/policies' -OutputType PSObject |
    Select-Object -ExpandProperty value |
    Select-Object displayName, state

# Who holds standing Global Administrator
Invoke-MgGraphRequest -OutputType PSObject -Uri (
    "v1.0/roleManagement/directory/roleAssignments?`$filter=roleDefinitionId eq " +
    "'62e90394-69f5-4237-9190-012177145e10'&`$expand=principal")
```

Record four things before you close the session: **the cloud, the license tier, the Conditional Access baseline, and the count of standing admins**. Those four determine what is possible in every conversation that follows.

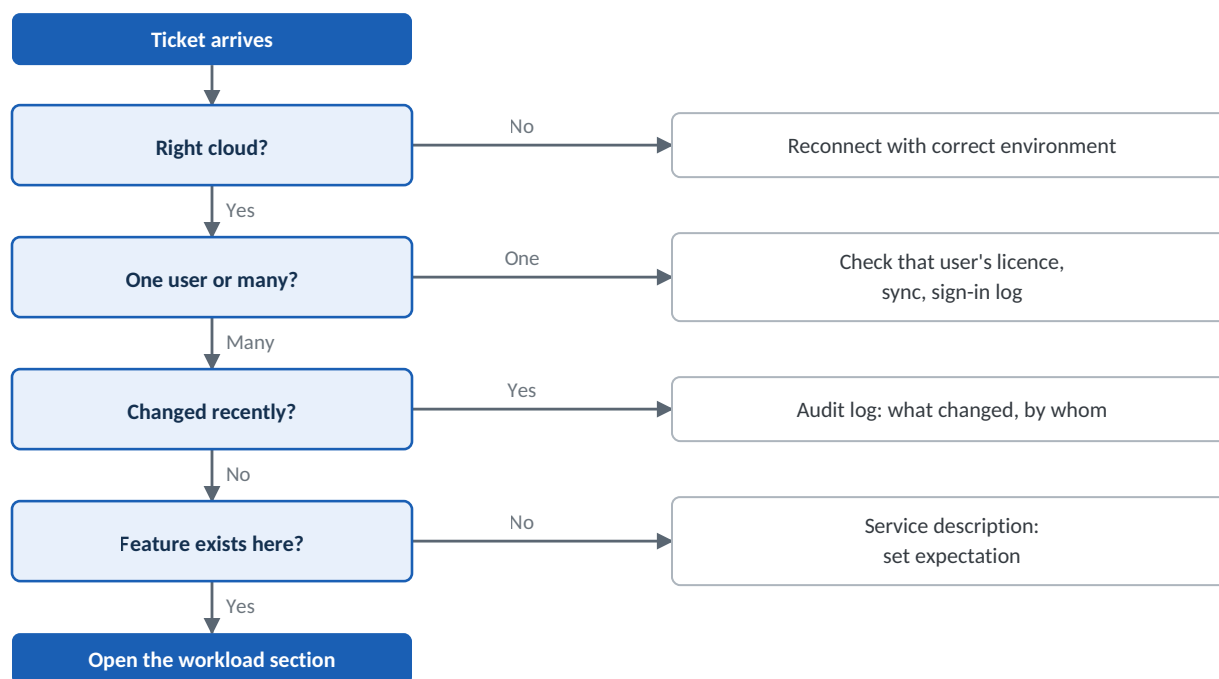
Red flags worth escalating on day one

Finding	Why it is urgent
No break-glass accounts	One CA mistake locks out every administrator
Federation certificate expiring within 60 days	Tenant-wide authentication outage, no warning to users
Unified audit log disabled	Evidence gap that cannot be backfilled
Standing Global Admin above two	Credential compromise means full tenant compromise
Legacy authentication reachable	Every MFA control is bypassable
Sharing set to <i>Anyone</i> links with CUI present	Potential reportable spillage

3. Using the symptom index

Sections 4 to 13 are organized by what the ticket says, not by what the cause turns out to be. Each entry reads symptom, likely causes ranked by frequency, the check, the fix, and how to stop it recurring.

Before opening a workload section, run the four-step triage. It resolves a surprising share of gov tenant tickets on its own.



Four-step triage. Run it before opening a workload section.

Step 1 — confirm the cloud. Get `-MgContext` and the tenant's initial domain. A `.onmicrosoft.us` domain is GCC High or DoD.

Step 2 — scope it. One user is a licensing, sync or per-user assignment problem. Many users is a policy or service problem.

Step 3 — check what changed. The Entra audit log and Purview unified audit log answer “it worked yesterday” faster than any amount of reasoning does.

Step 4 — confirm the feature exists here. Before troubleshooting a GCC High problem, verify the feature has actually shipped to GCC High. A meaningful fraction of escalations are features that were never there.

4. Connection and tooling

The cheapest section to master and the one that saves the most time. Nearly every entry here is a missing environment parameter.

4.1 “Connect-MgGraph succeeds but the tenant looks empty”

You authenticated to the commercial instance of a tenant that lives in GCC High, or to a personal account. The connection is real, the directory is not the one you wanted.

- **Check:** `Get-MgContext | Select Environment, TenantId` — Environment must read `USGov` or `USGovDoD`.
- **Fix:** `Connect-MgGraph -Environment USGov -TenantId <domain>`.
- **Prevent:** never call `Connect-MgGraph` without `-Environment` in a script that may run against a sovereign tenant. Wrap connection in a broker function.

4.2 “Exchange Online cmdlets fail after a successful connection”

`Connect-ExchangeOnline` defaults to commercial endpoints.

- **Fix:** `Connect-ExchangeOnline -ExchangeEnvironmentName 0365USGovGCCHigh` (or `0365USGovDoD`).
- **Note:** GCC moderate uses the default — no parameter. Passing the GCC High value against a GCC tenant fails.

4.3 “Teams cmdlets return nothing or throw on connect”

- **Fix:** `Connect-MicrosoftTeams -TeamsEnvironmentName TeamsGCCH` (or `TeamsDOD`). Commercial and GCC pass nothing.

4.4 “An old script that used to work now errors on a missing cmdlet”

The MSOnline and AzureAD modules are retired. Their `-AzureEnvironmentName USGovernment` pattern no longer applies.

- **Fix:** port to Microsoft.Graph PowerShell and Exchange Online V3.
- **Prevent:** grep the tooling share for `Connect-MsolService` and `Connect-AzureAD` and triage what turns up before it fails in production.

4.5 “Scripts on the share are blocked by execution policy”

A UNC path expressed as an IP address places files in the Internet zone.

- **Fix:** reference the share by hostname. `Unblock-File` as a stopgap, not a policy.

4.6 “Graph call returns 403 despite Global Administrator”

Delegated scope not consented, app-only permission not granted, or the API is unavailable in this cloud.

- **Check:** `(Get-MgContext).Scopes` for the delegated case; for app-only, the service principal's app role assignments.
- **Fix:** reconnect requesting the scope, or grant admin consent on the app registration.
- **Watch for:** the third case. Some Graph surfaces genuinely do not exist in sovereign clouds. A 403 that persists with correct consent may be an availability gap — confirm before opening a support case.

4.7 “A vendor's PowerShell module or SaaS integration does not work in GCC High”

The vendor has no GovCloud tenant, so their multi-tenant application does not exist in the sovereign directory to consent to.

- **Check:** search the enterprise applications gallery in the tenant itself, not commercial documentation.
- **Fix:** manual SAML or OIDC integration if the vendor supports it; otherwise the answer to the client is no.
- **Prevent:** add “does this vendor operate in GCC High” to procurement review. Finding out after purchase is a recurring and expensive pattern.

5. Identity and authentication

5.1 “User cannot complete MFA after their phone was replaced”

- **Check:** authentication methods registered for the user; whether a Temporary Access Pass policy exists.
- **Fix:** issue a TAP rather than disabling MFA. Disabling it, even briefly, is the single most common way a compliant tenant becomes non-compliant.
- **Prevent:** enable TAP tenant-wide and document the identity-proofing step the help desk must perform before issuing one. In a CUI environment that proofing step is itself an auditable control.

5.2 “Smartcard or CAC sign-in stopped working”

Usually an expired or untrusted certificate authority in the Entra CBA configuration, or a username binding mismatch after a UPN change.

- **Check:** the CBA trust store contents and expiry; the binding rule against the user's certificate subject.
- **Fix:** upload the renewed CA certificate; correct the binding.
- **Prevent:** track CA certificate expiry in the same calendar as federation certificates. Both cause tenant-wide outages and neither warns you.

5.3 “Users prompted for MFA constantly”

Sign-in frequency configured aggressively in Conditional Access, persistent browser session disabled, or device not registered so no compliant-device signal exists.

- **Check:** the sign-in frequency and persistence settings across CA policies; whether the device shows compliant.
- **Fix:** usually enroll the device rather than relax the policy.

5.4 “Service account or application stopped authenticating”

- **Check, in order:** client secret expiry, certificate expiry, whether a new CA policy now catches the account, and whether legacy auth was disabled.
- **Fix:** rotate to certificate credentials rather than issuing a new secret.
- **Prevent:** a scheduled report of application credentials expiring within 60 days. This is the highest-value ten lines of Graph automation you will write in the first month.

5.5 “New hire cannot sign in at all”

- **Check:** licence assigned, sync completed if hybrid, UPN suffix routable, account enabled, and whether a CA policy scoped to a group they are not in is blocking them.
- **Note:** in hybrid environments a new account can exist in AD for a full sync cycle before it is usable. Set the expectation with the client rather than troubleshooting.

5.6 “Phishing-resistant MFA required for CMMC but users are on SMS”

- **Fix path:** enable FIDO2 and certificate-based authentication first, enroll users, then disable SMS, voice and email OTP in the authentication methods policy, then add an authentication strength requirement to Conditional Access. In that order.

Do not disable weak methods before stronger ones are enrolled. That locks out everyone who has not registered.

6. Conditional Access

6.1 “Everyone is locked out”

The emergency case. Work the recovery path, not the diagnosis.

1. Sign in with a break-glass account. It is cloud-only and excluded from every policy, which is the entire reason it exists.
2. If no break-glass account exists, Microsoft support can help, but expect hours — and in GCC High the support queue is screened US persons only, which is smaller.
3. Set the offending policy to `disabled`, not deleted. You need it for the postmortem.
4. Re-enable in report-only and review the impact before enforcing again.

Prevent: two break-glass accounts, FIDO2 keys in separate physical custody, sign-in alerting on both, and a quarterly test that they actually work. An untested break-glass account is a theory.

6.2 “One group of users is blocked and nobody knows why”

Policies are additive and a block wins over every grant. Overlapping policies from different projects are the usual cause.

- **Check:** the sign-in log entry for an affected user, Conditional Access tab. It names every policy evaluated and the result of each.
- **Fix:** adjust the policy the log names, not the one you suspect.

6.3 “Access from outside the US is not blocked”

For ITAR this is the control an assessor asks about first.

- **Fix:** a country named location holding the permitted countries, then a policy for all users, all cloud apps, include any location, exclude the named location, grant block. Break-glass excluded.
- **Caveat:** location is determined by IP geolocation and is defeatable by VPN. It is a necessary control, not a sufficient one. Pair it with compliant-device requirements, and say so when a client asks whether it is enough.

6.4 “Report-only policies have been sitting unpromoted for months”

Common in inherited tenants and it looks like coverage while providing none.

- **Check:** every policy whose state is `enabledForReportingButNotEnforced`, with its creation date.
- **Fix:** review report-only sign-in impact, then enable. Anything over a quarter old should be enabled or deleted.

6.5 “A policy exclusion list has grown to dozens of accounts”

Exclusions accumulate as one-off fixes and quietly become the real policy.

- **Fix:** replace individual exclusions with a single named exception group, with membership reviewed quarterly through an access review.
- **For the assessor:** an undocumented exclusion is a finding. A documented, reviewed, time-bound exception is not.

6.6 “A new legacy-auth block broke a multifunction printer or batch job”

- **Check:** report-only sign-in logs filtered to the *other client* app type, over a full month. Monthly batch jobs are invisible in a week of data.
- **Fix:** move the device or job to modern auth, certificate-based SMTP, or an internal relay. A permanent exclusion is the last resort and needs documenting.

7. Hybrid identity and directory sync

7.1 “Changes in AD are not appearing in the cloud”

- **Check, in order:** sync service running, last successful sync time, whether the object is in an OU inside sync scope, whether a sync error is quarantining it, and whether staging mode was left on after a migration.
- **Common gov-specific cause:** Entra Connect reinstalled or rebuilt against the wrong cloud. The service runs, reports healthy, and syncs to a directory nobody is looking at.
- **Fix:** reconfigure for `AzureUSGovernment`. Verify by confirming a known object appears in the sovereign tenant, not by trusting the wizard.

7.2 “Duplicate or conflicting objects after a merger”

Usually a proxy address or UPN collision, or an object that was soft-matched incorrectly.

- **Check:** the sync error report and the object's immutable ID against the cloud object.
- **Fix:** resolve the attribute collision in AD, then force a delta sync. Hard-matching by immutable ID is a last resort and easy to get wrong.

7.3 “Federation certificate is about to expire”

This causes a total authentication outage with no user-facing warning.

- **Prevent:** calendar the renewal at 90, 60 and 30 days. Track it alongside CBA trust certificates and application credentials in one expiry report.
- **Strategic fix:** move from federation to password hash sync or pass-through authentication where the client's requirements allow. Fewer moving parts, fewer outages, and cloud authentication keeps working when the on-premises environment does not.

7.4 “Users can sign in to cloud apps but not on-premises resources, or vice versa”

- **Check:** which authentication method is in play for the failing direction, and whether Seamless SSO is configured.
- **Note:** the two directions fail independently. Confirm which one is actually broken before changing anything.

7.5 “Hybrid Azure AD join devices never register”

- **Check:** the service connection point in AD, the device's `dsregcmd /status` output, whether the registration endpoint is reachable, and whether the device OU is in sync scope.
- **Gov-specific:** the device registration endpoints differ in sovereign clouds. A proxy or firewall allow-list built from commercial documentation will silently block registration.

7.6 “Password writeback is not working”

- **Check:** the feature is enabled in Entra Connect, the service account holds reset-password rights on the target OUs, and the licence supports it.
- **Order matters:** self-service password reset without writeback in a hybrid tenant resets the cloud password only, and users then cannot sign in to domain-joined machines. That ticket arrives as “password reset broke my computer.”

8. Intune, Autopilot and endpoint

8.1 “Autopilot device shows the wrong profile or none at all”

- **Check:** hardware hash imported, device present in Windows Autopilot devices, group membership resolved (dynamic groups take time), profile assigned to that group, and the profile assignment status on the device object.
- **Fix:** most commonly the device is not yet in the dynamic group. Confirm membership before re-importing anything.
- **Prevent:** vendor-supplied hashes at procurement rather than manual collection. Manual hash collection does not scale past a few dozen machines.

8.2 “Enrollment fails with a licensing or authority error”

- **Check:** the user holds an Intune licence, MDM authority is set, enrollment restrictions permit the platform, and the device is not already enrolled to another tenant.
- **Gov-specific:** the enrollment service endpoints are the `.us` variants. A proxy allow-list copied from commercial documentation blocks enrollment and the error message does not say so.

8.3 “A setting is not applying and the report says conflict”

Two policies assigning the same setting to the same device. Intune does not pick a winner — the setting fails.

- **Check:** per-setting status on the device, which names both policies.
- **Fix:** consolidate to one policy per setting per group. Settings catalog rather than a mix of templates and legacy profiles.
- **Prevent:** one baseline policy set, scoped by ring, with additions made to the baseline instead of alongside it. Fleet-wide conflict is nearly always an artifact of policies created by different people at different times for different projects.

8.4 “Win32 app installs succeed in testing and fail in production”

- **Check:** detection rule correctness, requirement rules, whether the install runs as system or user, the 64-bit versus 32-bit PowerShell context, and the actual exit code in the Intune management extension log on the device.
- **Most common cause:** a detection rule that matches during testing for a reason unrelated to the install.

8.5 “Compliance shows non-compliant with no obvious reason”

- **Check:** which specific setting failed, grace period configuration, and whether the device has checked in recently. A device that has not checked in is not non-compliant, it is stale — different problem.
- **Interaction:** a non-compliant device combined with a compliant-device Conditional Access grant produces a sign-in block. The user reports an access problem, not a compliance problem.

8.6 “Feature X is missing from the Intune console”

Remote Help, Windows Autopatch, Endpoint Privilege Management and similar add-ons have reached the sovereign clouds on their own schedules.

- **Check:** the Intune service plan availability for GCC High before troubleshooting.
- **Answer to the client:** confirm from the service description, give a date if Microsoft has published one, and do not promise a roadmap item.

8.7 “Local administrator rights are everywhere”

- **Fix:** deploy Windows LAPS through Intune, then remove standing local admin, then provide an elevation path for the genuine cases.
- **Order matters:** removing local admin before an elevation path exists generates a help desk flood and gets the project reversed.

9. Exchange Online and mail flow

9.1 “Mail to a partner is failing or being rejected”

- **Check:** message trace first, always. It names the failure rather than leaving you to guess.
- **Then:** connectors, TLS enforcement between the domains, and whether a transport rule is matching unexpectedly.
- **Gov-specific:** forced TLS with a partner whose mail platform does not support it fails closed. In a CUI environment that is correct behaviour and the fix is a conversation with the partner, not a relaxed connector.

9.2 “Encrypted mail to an external recipient arrives as a portal link they cannot use”

Message encryption to recipients outside the tenant, especially across the sovereign boundary, uses a portal experience that surprises people.

- **Fix:** set the expectation before deployment, not after the first complaint.
- **Alternative:** for a regular partner, a secure file transfer channel or a properly configured B2B guest arrangement is usually a better experience than encrypted mail.

9.3 “A multifunction printer stopped sending scans”

Basic authentication for SMTP. Nearly always this.

- **Fix options, in order of preference:** move to an internal relay that authenticates with a certificate; use high-volume SMTP where available; or, last resort, a documented exception for that device with a restricted source IP.
- **Prevent:** inventory every device and application that sends mail before disabling legacy authentication, not after.

9.4 “A shared mailbox is accessible to people who should not have it”

- **Check:** full access, send-as and send-on-behalf permissions separately — they are three different grants and people confuse them.
- **Note:** permissions can be inherited from a group nobody remembers. Check group-based grants before concluding it was assigned directly.

9.5 “Litigation hold or retention is not doing what the client expects”

- **Clarify first:** hold preserves, retention deletes on a schedule, and they interact. A client asking for “seven year retention” often means “preserve for seven years,” which is a different configuration.
- **Check:** which policy applies to the mailbox, and whether the mailbox is licensed for the feature.

9.6 “Exchange hybrid is broken after an on-premises change”

- **Check:** hybrid configuration wizard last run, certificate validity on the on-premises endpoints, connector configuration, and whether a firewall change closed the required path.
- **Note:** free/busy and mail flow fail independently. Confirm which one the user is actually reporting.

10. Teams

10.1 “We cannot chat with a partner organization”

Federation between a sovereign tenant and a commercial tenant requires configuration on both sides, and the failure is silent from the user's perspective.

- **Check:** external access configuration and the allowed domain list in both tenants.
- **Fix:** add the partner domain on your side, then ask the partner to do the same. One-sided configuration produces exactly the same symptom as no configuration.
- **Expectation:** not every commercial Teams feature works across the boundary. Confirm before promising a workflow depends on it.

10.2 “External participants cannot join a meeting”

- **Check:** anonymous join settings, the meeting policy applied to the organizer, and lobby configuration.
- **Note in CUI environments:** anonymous join is frequently disabled deliberately. Before changing it, confirm whether that was a security decision rather than an oversight. Reversing someone's control is worse than the ticket.

10.3 “Recordings or transcripts are missing”

- **Check:** the meeting policy allows recording, the organizer's OneDrive has space and exists, and whether the feature has shipped to this cloud at all.
- **Gov-specific:** transcription and some intelligent-recap features have lagged in GCC High. Verify availability before treating it as a fault.

10.4 “Guest cannot access a team they were added to”

- **Check, in order:** guest access enabled at the tenant level, guest invitations permitted in Entra, the cross-tenant access configuration if the guest is in a different cloud, the invitation actually redeemed, and the team's own guest setting.
- **Most common in GCC High:** the cross-cloud endpoint is not enabled, so the invitation sends but cannot be redeemed. See section 11.

10.5 “Teams Phone features are missing”

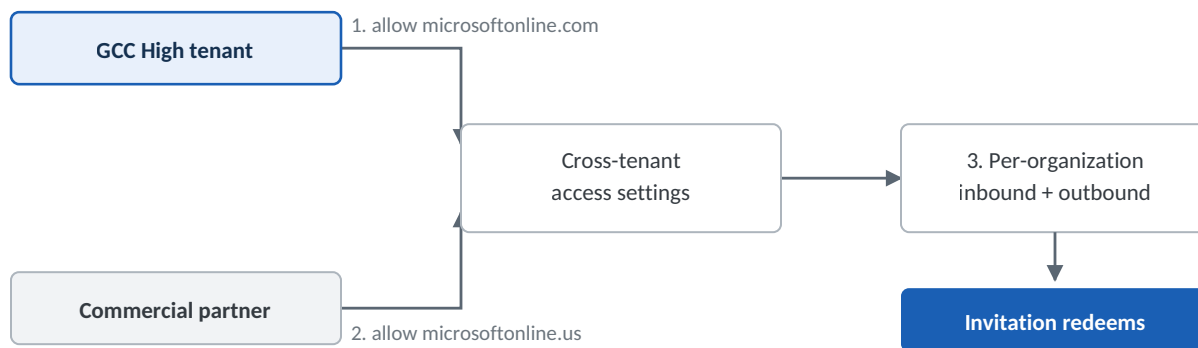
Teams Phone capability in the sovereign clouds trails commercial and some calling plans are not offered.

- **Check:** the service description and what the tenant is actually licensed for, before design work begins.
- **Design note:** Direct Routing is frequently the answer in GCC High where a calling plan is not available. Confirm the session border controller vendor supports the sovereign cloud.

11. SharePoint, OneDrive and external sharing

11.1 “Guest invitation sent but the partner cannot redeem it”

The signature GCC High problem. A commercial-tenant guest cannot redeem an invitation from a sovereign tenant until cross-cloud collaboration is enabled on both sides.



Cross-cloud B2B requires configuration on both sides before an invitation can be redeemed.

- **Fix:** enable the partner cloud under Microsoft cloud settings, have the partner do the same, then configure per-organization inbound and outbound settings on both sides.
- **Escalation note:** this arrives as a help desk ticket about a broken invitation and is actually a tenant configuration project involving another company. Set that expectation early rather than promising a same-day fix.

11.2 “Anyone links are enabled in a tenant holding CUI”

- **Check:** tenant-level sharing setting and per-site overrides, which can be more permissive than the tenant default suggests.
- **Fix:** tenant setting to *new and existing guests* or to internal only, then audit existing anonymous links and expire them.
- **Important:** existing anonymous links keep working after you change the tenant setting. Changing the policy is not the same as closing the exposure.

11.3 “A user cannot access a site they should have”

- **Check:** direct permissions, group-based access, whether the site is in a sensitivity-labelled container with access restrictions, and whether Conditional Access is blocking based on device or location.
- **Note:** container labels can restrict access in ways that look like a broken permission. Check the label before rebuilding permissions.

11.4 “Guest accounts have accumulated for years”

- **Fix:** an access review over the guest population, then an inactive-guest cleanup, then a recurring review.
- **For the assessor:** unreviewed external access is a finding against several 800-171 controls. A quarterly review with records is not.

11.5 “External sharing works for one site and not another”

Site-level settings cannot exceed the tenant setting but can be more restrictive. Someone tightened one site and forgot.

- **Check:** the site's own sharing configuration against the tenant default.

11.6 “Multi-geo or a specific data residency feature is unavailable”

Multi-geo is not offered in GCC High. Data residency questions in a sovereign tenant are answered by the authorization boundary rather than by tenant configuration.

- **Answer to the client:** the boundary is the control. Point them at the FedRAMP authorization rather than looking for a setting.

12. Purview, labelling and audit

12.1 “We have no CUI labelling and an assessment is coming”

- **Start with the taxonomy, not the tooling.** A label set that does not match how the client actually marks documents will be ignored by users and will fail in practice.
- **Minimum viable set:** Public, Internal, Controlled Unclassified Information, and where ITAR applies, an ITAR label with stronger protection.
- **Sequence:** publish labels to a pilot group, add auto-labelling in simulation mode, review what it catches and what it wrongly catches, then enforce.

Do not turn on auto-labelling with encryption across the whole tenant on day one. Encrypting the wrong documents is very difficult to undo at scale.

12.2 “ITAR data needs protection Microsoft cannot see”

Double Key Encryption is the answer for the narrow set of data requiring a key the service provider does not hold.

- **Trade-off:** DKE-protected content loses service-side capabilities — search, eDiscovery, co-authoring. Apply it to the smallest possible set.
- **Client conversation:** ask what genuinely requires it rather than applying it broadly. Most content that people assume needs DKE does not.

12.3 “The auditor is asking for logs we do not have”

- **Check:** whether the unified audit log is enabled, and the retention period the licence provides.
- **Hard truth:** audit data that was not retained cannot be recovered. Enable it on the first day of any engagement, before anything else, because the gap only grows.
- **Fix forward:** enable, extend retention where licensing allows, and export to external storage if the client's requirement exceeds what the tenant retains.

12.4 “DLP is generating too many false positives”

- **Check:** the sensitive information types in use and their confidence levels.
- **Fix:** tune confidence and instance counts, use exact data match where the client can supply a source list, and run in simulation before enforcing.
- **Prevent:** every DLP policy starts in simulation. Enforcing a noisy policy trains users to ignore the warnings, which is worse than no policy.

12.5 “eDiscovery or search returns nothing for a location we know holds data”

- **Check:** licensing for the eDiscovery tier in use, whether the location is indexed, whether content is DKE-protected, and whether the searching account holds the right role.
- **Note:** roles for eDiscovery are separate from Global Administrator. A Global Admin who has not been added to the eDiscovery role group sees nothing, which looks like missing data.

12.6 “Which Purview features exist in GCC High?”

Parity here is the least predictable of any workload, and it shifts.

- **Rule:** confirm against the current service description before designing. Treat any Purview capability as unavailable in GCC High until verified, rather than the other way round.

13. Applications, automation and Power Platform

13.1 “An integration broke and nobody knows why”

- **Check first:** credential expiry. Client secrets expire silently and take the integration with them.
- **Then:** whether a new Conditional Access policy now catches the service principal, whether a required permission was revoked, and whether a consent policy change blocked it.
- **Prevent:** a scheduled report of application credentials expiring within 60 days, delivered to a human. Certificates instead of secrets wherever the application supports them.

13.2 “An app has permissions it should not”

- **Check:** app role assignments on the service principal, who granted consent, and when — the audit log has this.
- **Fix:** revoke and re-grant at least privilege. Expect to break something, so coordinate with the application owner rather than doing it quietly.
- **Prevent:** disable user consent for applications, route requests through an admin consent workflow, and review consented applications quarterly.

13.3 “A Power Automate flow works in commercial and not in GCC High”

The connector does not exist in the sovereign environment. Third-party connectors are largely unavailable there.

- **Check:** connector availability in the target environment, not in documentation.
- **Fix:** rebuild with first-party connectors, or a custom connector against an API the tenant can reach, or move the logic to a scheduled script outside Power Platform.
- **Prevent:** design Power Platform solutions against the GCC High connector list from the start. Porting a commercial flow afterwards is frequently a rewrite.

13.4 “We need multi-tenant visibility across our gov clients”

Microsoft 365 Lighthouse is not available in GCC High, which is the central operational gap for an MSP serving that market.

- **Fix:** per-client app registrations with read-only scopes, a config file listing tenants, and a Graph-based runner that loops them. Store results centrally and report on drift.

- **Delegated administration:** the partner model for sovereign clouds differs from commercial. Confirm the current authorization path before designing an access model around it.

13.5 “A scheduled automation runs against the wrong tenant”

High-consequence failure mode when one team manages many tenants.

- **Fix:** every automation asserts the expected tenant ID after connecting and exits if it does not match. Four lines, prevents a category of incident.
- **Also:** separate credentials per tenant, never a shared one, and read-only by default with write credentials checked out deliberately.

14. Reference

Connection parameters by cloud

Module	Commercial / GCC	GCC High	DoD
Microsoft.Graph	-Environment Global	-Environment USGov	-Environment USGovDoD
ExchangeOnlineManagement	default	-ExchangeEnvironmentName 0365USGovGCCHigh	-ExchangeEnvironmentName 0365USGovDoD
MicrosoftTeams	default	-TeamsEnvironmentName TeamsGCCH	-TeamsEnvironmentName TeamsDOD
Az	-Environment AzureCloud	-Environment AzureUSGovernment	-Environment AzureUSGovernment

Portals by cloud

Portal	Commercial / GCC	GCC High	DoD
Entra	entra.microsoft.com	entra.microsoft.us	entra.microsoft.us
Intune	intune.microsoft.com	intune.microsoft.us	intune.microsoft.us
Defender	security.microsoft.com	security.microsoft.us	security.apps.mil
Purview	purview.microsoft.com	purview.microsoft.us	compliance.apps.mil
Azure	portal.azure.com	portal.azure.us	portal.azure.us

What Graph can and cannot reach

Domain	Graph coverage	Otherwise use
Entra identity, roles, PIM	full read and write	—
Conditional Access, named locations	full read and write	—
Authentication methods policy	full read and write	—
Cross-tenant access settings	full read and write	—
Intune configuration, apps, Autopilot	full read and write	—
Application registrations and consent	full read and write	—
SharePoint tenant sharing settings	partial	PnP.PowerShell
Sensitivity labels	read only	Security & Compliance PowerShell
DLP policies	limited	Security & Compliance PowerShell
Audit configuration	limited	Security & Compliance PowerShell
Exchange Online configuration	none	ExchangeOnlineManagement
Teams policies	none	MicrosoftTeams
Retention and eDiscovery	none	Security & Compliance PowerShell

Roughly half of a realistic posture rule set is fully automatable through Graph alone, and about seventy percent is detectable if the tool accepts multiple modules. Saying that accurately is worth more than claiming Graph does everything.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
CUI	Controlled Unclassified Information — government information requiring safeguarding without being classified
DFARS 252.204-7012	Contract clause requiring NIST SP 800-171 for covered defense information
NIST SP 800-171	The 110 control requirements for protecting CUI in nonfederal systems
CMMC Level 2	Cybersecurity Maturity Model Certification aligned to 800-171, with third-party assessment
C3PAO	The accredited organization that performs a CMMC assessment
SPRS	Supplier Performance Risk System — where a contractor's self-assessment score is posted
ITAR	Export control regime for defense articles and technical data; access by a foreign person is an export
US person	Citizen, lawful permanent resident, or protected individual — the ITAR access standard
FedRAMP High	The authorization level GCC High and DoD operate under
IL2 / IL4 / IL5	DoD impact levels; GCC is IL2, GCC High is IL4, DoD is IL5
DIB	Defense Industrial Base — the contractor community these tenants serve
DKE	Double Key Encryption — content protection with a key the service provider does not hold

A note on currency

Feature parity between commercial and sovereign clouds moves continuously, and several statements in this runbook will age. Before any of it reaches a client commitment, verify against the current Microsoft 365 Government service description. Treat this document as a structure for thinking, not as a source of record.